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Doubtbound

13 November 2025

I may have been cruel, O Holy Father.
I may have broken what none can restore.
I may have sinned and forgotten.
Unworthy of mercy, condemned.

Oh, god, of shame,
you grant no absolution,
but demand confession without end.
I name you not as god but as disease.

I no longer weep for imagined crimes.
I no longer scour for certainty.
I no longer bargain with ghosts.
I forsake the dance that grinds the soul.

I accept that I may be wretched.
I accept that grace may never come.
This confession is fractured, profane, and enough.
I choose to walk onward, unredeemed and unbound.

The reality stack

1 April 2026

A stack is layers where each rests on the one below — a tech stack, rock strata, floors in a building. The reality stack turns “is this just the way things are?” into “which layer does this sit at, and therefore how contingent, how mutable, and how accountable is it?” It is not metaphysics but a teaching device — descriptive in form, normatively motivated: it exists to make a particular claim about inequality arguable.

Three layers and a cross-section

The **physical layer** is invariant law — gravity, thermodynamics, the speed of light. You cannot negotiate with it; it gives rise to everything above without determining it.

The **material layer** is the physical world in the mode of human encounter: bodies, biology, climate, geography, and the infrastructure built into them. Not philosophical materialism — physics seen through what humans need, are stuck with, and have made: the calorie requirement of a body, the river that is here and not there, the concrete a city is made of.

The **social layer** is constructed — arrangements humans make collectively, constrained by the material but not determined by it. Two societies with identical material conditions can organise themselves in opposite ways, and historically have. It is where power, roles, norms, and institutions live — and the layer people most often mistake for one below. Which side of the road you drive on, marriage, money.

The **agent** is not a fourth layer but a cross-section, a point where all three meet: a physical body, material needs, and a social layer carried inside as language, shame, politeness. What is purely agent? Very little — a flinch, a refusal. Yet the cross-section is the only site from which any of it can be questioned. Agents together reshape the social, which reshapes the material, which reshapes what is possible.

Locating a thing

To test where something sits, ask: *if the other layers varied independently, would this vary with them, or hold constant?* Gravity holds across all societies and bodies — physical. A body’s calorie requirement holds across societies but varies across species — material. Which side of the road cars drive on varies across societies under identical material conditions — social. The test is not a decision procedure: gender, race, disease, addiction pass it ambiguously, and that is the point — the framework surfaces the dispute rather than resolving it.

This is why we distrust the word **natural**: it often smuggles a social claim down to the physical layer, where it can no longer be argued with. “Hierarchy is natural” makes hierarchy a law of gravity; “it is human nature to be selfish” relocates a collective behaviour to physics against the anthropological evidence. The word has honest uses; the suspicion is of the move — a way to escape accountability by crossing into a layer where accountability does not apply.

Three spectrums run through the stack. **Contingency** — whether it could have been otherwise: zero at the physical, some at the material, a great deal at the social. **Mutability** — how readily it changes: gravity never, material conditions over generations, social arrangements within a lifetime, an agent’s position in a moment. **Accountability** — not “who caused it” but “who, going forward, is situated to change it”; responsibility can be collective and forward-looking even when no individual chose the outcome. They come apart, and the interesting political arguments are always about which axis a dispute is on.

So when you catch yourself asking “is this just the way things are?” — locate the thing in the stack. If it sits at the physical layer, accept it. If it sits anywhere above, the question has an answer: it is this way because of the layer it sits at, the path it took, and the feedback that locked it in. None of that is destiny. That is the whole point of naming the layers.

Definitions of power

30 May 2026

A working list of definitions.

Power

Power is the capacity to bring about outcomes — by acting directly, by shifting another agent's behaviour, by setting the conditions under which others act, or by producing agents and possibilities that didn't exist before. It comes in five overlapping forms. The English word "power" smears across all five; pulling them apart is most of the work.

Power-to

Power-to is the capacity to act — to make, to bring something about — independent of any other agent. A solo inventor with a working prototype has it without power over anyone. It is the substrate of the rest: you can't shift B, sustain a structure, or write the rules without first being able to act. When people demand "more power" in their lives, they usually mean this.

Agentic power

Agentic power is the capacity of one agent to shift another's behaviour toward outcomes the first prefers, against the second's resistance, across some domain. A has power over B to the degree B's behaviour tracks A's preferences more than it would in A's absence — no counterfactual gap, no power. It is capacity, not exercise (an unfired gun is still a threat), and always over some domain: a landlord controls where a tenant sleeps, not what they read.

Structural power

Structural power is the capacity of a system — a market, a bureaucracy, a body of law, a norm, an infrastructure — to shift behaviour against people's preferences with no agent willing the shift. The signature matches agentic power; the counterfactual differs: there is no A to remove. A worker taking a low wage is coerced not by the employer but by the labour market — a structure with no author, experienced by those inside it as a fact of the world rather than a thing being done to them.

Constitutive power

Constitutive power is the capacity to set the structure others then operate inside — to write the rules, pick the defaults, design the platform, draw the map. Agentic in form (someone wills it into being), its effect runs through structural power (once embedded, it shifts behaviour without further input). It is the highest leverage per unit effort — a structure shapes every interaction it mediates, for as long as it lasts — then decays into structural power with no author, which is why old constitutive choices are so hard to undo.

Generative power

Generative power is the capacity to produce new agents, capacities, desires, or possibilities — to bring into existence what wasn't there before, rather than shift or arrange what already is. The other four operate on a given set of agents and options; this one changes the set. It runs opposite to the standard image of power: it gives you wants and self-conceptions you wouldn't otherwise have had. It is the hardest to resist — by the time you can name yourself its subject, it has already made the "you" who would resist.

Egalitarianism

An egalitarian society simultaneously raises the floor of power-to, caps concentrations of power-over, distributes constitutive power broadly, and biases structural power toward enabling rather than constraining. Four dials, not one — win on one while losing the others and it isn't egalitarian. The floor, not the average, is what counts; power-over is capped rather than abolished, since the target is to prevent domination, not authority; and the rule-writing is distributed — the dial most often left out and the one that quietly sets the rest. They have to move together or they undo each other.

Legitimacy

Legitimacy is the property that makes power voluntarily accepted by those subject to it: legitimate power runs on compliance, illegitimate on enforcement. It is a property power can have, not a sixth form — any of the kinds above can be legitimate, illegitimate, or contested. Two senses get confused. *Descriptive*: those subject to it actually accept it as rightful — a fact about behaviour. *Normative*: it meets an external standard — consent, procedural fairness, justice — a claim about what ought to be acceptable. They come apart both ways: a regime can be widely accepted yet unjust (most stable tyrannies), or normatively legitimate yet rejected on the ground (most failed reforms).

Two categories of inequality

28 June 2026

There are two kinds of inequality, and telling them apart is the whole game. Confuse them and you will either blame people for outcomes nobody chose, or excuse a rigged system as if it were weather. Most real inequality is a mix of the two — but they have different causes, different moral weight, and different cures, so it pays to pull them apart.

Emergent inequality

Emergent inequality is the gap that opens from fair-looking rules, with nobody intending it. Start everyone equal, hand them symmetric rules, run the system long enough, and you still get an oligarchy. Nobody cheats; the maths just favours someone.

Some games are rigged in a way no player can see. In the yard-sale model, two people repeatedly stake a fixed fraction of the *poorer* one's wealth on a fair coin — every bet is even, yet one player ends up with everything, because the same stake is ruin for the poor and pocket change for the rich. Multiplicative luck bites the same way: a 50% loss then a 50% gain leaves you at 75%, so a run of fair odds drifts the typical fortune toward zero even as the average climbs.

Small advantages compound. Money makes money — a fixed return turns any head-start into an exponential lead. A child who reads a little better at five gets more books and more praise, and by ten is years ahead. Attention flows to whoever already has it: links, citations, and followers all follow power laws, so a few hubs run away with the traffic — not because they are best, but because they arrived first.

And accidents harden into structure. Where your parents lived fixes your school, your peers, the air you breathe, and the network that will hire you — none of it chosen. A neighbourhood's rent creeps up, then crosses a line past which the people who gave it its character can no longer stay. The same recession that costs an investor a few years costs a worker their home. None of this was designed. All of it compounds.

Adversarial inequality

Adversarial inequality is the gap that specific, identifiable people open and defend because they profit from it. Here there are names, budgets, and lawyers. Where emergent inequality has a mechanism, this has a beneficiary — someone you can point at.

It works by **extraction** — taking a cut without adding anything. Landlords bank the value a neighbourhood's improvement creates; patent trolls sue instead of building; publishers lock publicly funded research behind paywalls they paid nothing to fill. The move is to sit between people and what they need, and charge for passage.

It works by **capture** — getting hold of the rules themselves. Industries staff the agencies meant to police them and end up drafting the regulations; district lines get drawn so elections are settled before anyone votes; the wealthy fund the lobbying that carves the tax loopholes only they can afford to use. The people the rules were meant to constrain become the people who write them.

It works by **suppression and enclosure** — shrinking what others hold. Employers keep wages down with non-competes and union-busting. Commons that were shared — land, water, knowledge, seed — get fenced off and rented back. Debt is structured so the borrower can never quite leave. Profit is kept; the harm is exported to poor neighbourhoods, offshore factories, the next generation.

And over all of it sits **narrative control** — the work of making the arrangement look natural, deserved, inevitable. Think tanks, owned media, and a curated vocabulary (“job creators”, “trickle-down”) exist so that the people the system fails will explain it to themselves as the way things simply have to be.

So what

In practice the two feed each other. Emergent dynamics open the gap; whoever lands on top then spends the winnings keeping it open — buying the think tanks, capturing the regulators, writing the rules. The emergence may be blameless. The maintenance almost never is.

The distinction matters because it kills a favourite excuse: *this is just what happens when free people get on with their lives, so nobody’s to blame and there’s nothing to be done*. Half true. Much inequality does arrive unintended — but a process can be innocent at the start and ugly at the end, and the sane response is to change the process, not to admire how cleverly it works. The other half is plainer once you look: rent-seekers, captured regulators, and paid-for stories are not accidents. They are load-bearing. They are how the structure stays upright.

The fix has one shape in both halves, even where the targets differ. Where the dynamics push the wrong way, build rules that push back — cap the runaway, tax the compounding, raise the floor. Where people have built machinery to stop you, confront it and take it apart. Neither is easy; neither is mysterious.

Inequality is a choice. It can be unchosen. The main thing keeping it in place is the belief that it can’t be.

What is matter?

4 July 2026

A summary of Noam Chomsky's [Language and Nature](#) (*Mind*, Vol. 104, Oxford University Press, 1995; PDF), archived by the Radical Anthropology Group as class text 095. The title is mine; the argument is his, and it is stranger than it looks.

The mind-body problem, in brief. We seem to be two things at once: a body — brain, neurons, matter under physical law — and a mind — thought, sensation, the felt redness of red. How can meat produce an inner life, and how can a weightless decision lift an arm? Fitting consciousness into a physical world with no evident room for it is the problem, and for three centuries it has been filed under *insoluble*.

Gilbert Ryle ridiculed Descartes's dualism as **the ghost in the machine**. The joke presumes we still know what the machine is. Chomsky's reply is that we lost it long ago — and that the ghost was never the difficulty.

1. **Matter, defined then destroyed.** The seventeenth-century *mechanical philosophy* held the world to be a machine: bodies act only by direct contact, and that contact was what “matter” *meant*. Descartes, unable to reduce the ordinary creative use of language to any such mechanism, posited a second substance, thought — and with it a real scientific question: how do the two touch?
2. **Newton dissolved the body, not the mind.** Gravity acts at a distance, through no contact at all — an “immaterial” force Newton himself judged an “absurdity” and never accepted (“I frame no hypotheses”). Leibniz and Huygens denounced it as a lapse into the occult. It was correct. What science expelled was therefore the machine, not the ghost; *body* is what vanished from the picture of the world.
3. **Materialism is therefore empty.** To say the mental “reduces to the physical” you need a prior notion of the physical — and since Newton there is none. “Matter” now means whatever the reigning theory invokes: fields, curved space, ten-dimensional strings, whatever is concocted next. Priestley drew the honest conclusion — not that all is matter, but that “the kind of matter on which the two-substance view is based does not exist.” Thought is simply what a certain organised system, the brain, does.
4. **So study mind as nature.** Treat language and mind by ordinary empirical inquiry, with no metaphysical wall between the “mental” and the “chemical.” Seek *unification*, not *reduction*: chemistry joined physics only after physics was overturned to receive it. Expect to leave common sense behind, exactly as physics left common-sense body behind.
5. **And keep the genuine mystery.** The *creative aspect* of language — speech endlessly novel, apt to the moment yet uncaused by it — was for the Cartesians the best proof of other minds. Of it, and of consciousness, we still have “only description and illustration,” no theory. Not the routine irreducibility science keeps absorbing, but perhaps a permanent bound on a biological creature's reach.

The message is at once deflationary and immense. The mind-body problem was never solved; it was dissolved, the moment the body dissolved. We are not ghosts trapped in machines — there are no machines, only a nature far stranger than common sense allows, of which thought is one more unexplained part. The confident materialism of our age mistakes its own vocabulary for the structure of the world; the hard-headed naturalist who swaps the old God for natural selection and pronounces nature transparent has merely inherited a faith on worse credentials.

Newton's lesson, still unlearned three centuries on: it is not mind that defies physics, but our idea of what physics is.

How does anarchism typically die

21 June 2026

Anarchism is often dismissed as never having been tried. It has — repeatedly, at real scale, governing millions of people. The pattern worth noticing is not that it never works, but *how* it ends.

The 23 cases in the appendix below are too few for statistics, but enough for a shape. Sort them by cause of death and one bar dwarfs the rest.

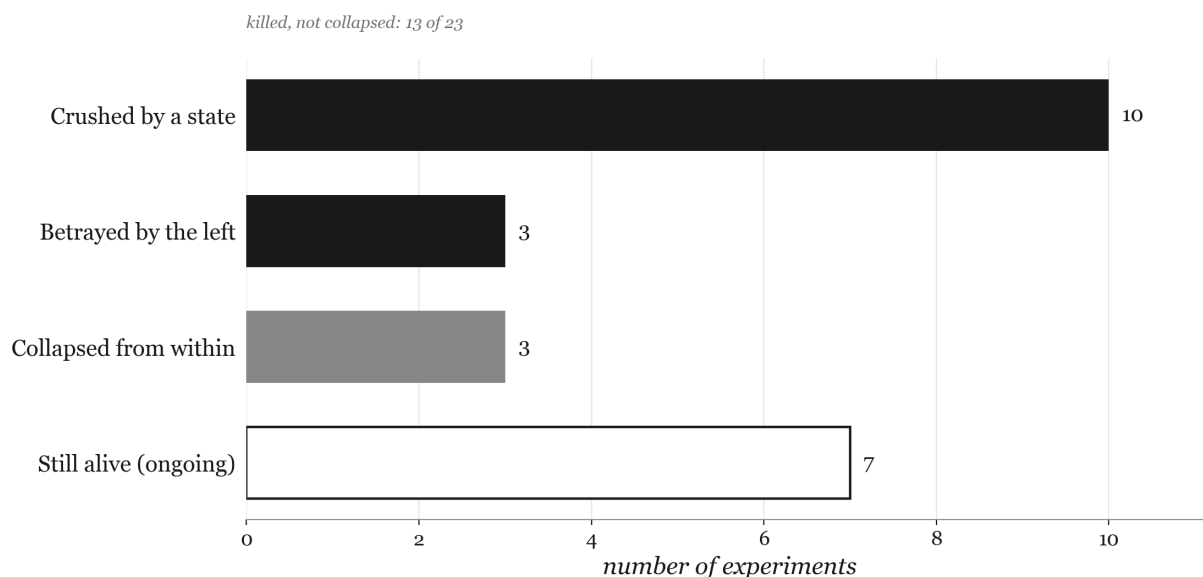


Figure 3: How the 23 anarchist experiments ended, tallied by cause: crushed by a state dwarfs the rest, while collapse-from-within is rare.

Of the 16 experiments that ended, only 3 actually *collapsed* from within. The other 13 were killed — 10 crushed by an enemy state, 3 betrayed by the authoritarian left they had fought alongside. The remaining 7 are still alive, and nearly all of them are small.

That inverts the usual obituary. Anarchism is supposed to fail because it cannot scale — because without a state it dissolves into chaos. But collapse-from-within is the rarest ending on the chart. Anarchism rarely dies of its own contradictions; it gets murdered, usually by a state, and at its largest by the left. The betrayals are few, but they land on the giants: the two largest experiments ever recorded, Makhno’s Free Territory and revolutionary Catalonia, were destroyed not by their declared enemies but by the Bolsheviks and Stalinists nominally on their side.

There is a sharper catch. The big modern cases anarchists point to — Rojava, Oaxaca, Cherán — are mostly broad popular fronts or indigenous autonomies that anarchists *joined* rather than authored. Strip those out and unmistakably anarchist self-government at scale almost vanishes from the record. The most unforgiving reading: large anarchism does not merely die young — it is rarely permitted to exist at all. Whether the small survivors represent endurance or surrender is the open question.

Appendix

The full record behind the chart, sorted by peak scale.

The **bold** phrase in *How it ended* is the load-bearing claim each source is cited for — the manner of death (or survival) that the chart and the central argument rest on. Start there when checking a reference.

† *Anarchist-**influenced** rather than anarchist-led — a popular front, indigenous communalism, or worker-cooperative movement that anarchists took part in or claim, rather than a card-carrying anarchist polity. Iceland is older and shakier still: it is cited mostly by anarcho-capitalists and is here only as the one pre-modern outlier.*

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
Revolutionary Catalonia & Aragon	Spain, 1936–1939	≈5–8 million in collectives	Be-trayed	Undermined by Stalinist allies , then defeated by Franco	source
Free Territory (Makhnovshchina)	Ukraine, 1918–1921	Up to ≈7 million	Be-trayed	Used then liquidated by the Bolsheviks once the Whites were beaten	source
Rojava (AANES)	North-east Syria, 2012–present	≈2–4 million	Alive	Survives under constant military threat from Turkey and others	source
Hungarian workers' councils	Hungary, 1956	Millions, briefly	Crushed	Crushed by Soviet tanks within weeks	source
Paris Commune	Paris, 1871	≈2 million	Crushed	Crushed by the French Army ; ≈20,000 killed in the <i>semaine sanglante</i>	source
Korean People's Association	Manchuria, 1929–1931	≈2 million	Crushed	Caught between Japanese imperial forces and Stalinists	source
Biennio Rosso	Italy, 1919–1920	≈600,000 workers	Collapsed	Collapsed ; cleared the path for Fascist reaction	source
Bavarian Council Republic †	Munich, 1919	≈600,000	Crushed	Stormed by the Freikorps ; Landauer murdered	source
Bakur self-rule †	South-east Turkey, 2015–2016	≈400,000	Crushed	Turkish army sieges ; districts levelled, trustees imposed	source
Zapatistas (EZLN)	Chiapas, Mexico, 1994–present	≈300,000	Alive	Survives , encircled and pressured by the Mexican state	source
Oaxaca Commune (APPO) †	Oaxaca, Mexico, 2006	≈200,000	Crushed	Federal police retook the city centre	source
Icelandic Commonwealth	Iceland, 930–1262	≈50,000	Collapsed	Collapsed into feuding chieftains ; absorbed by Norway	source
Strandzha Commune	Ottoman Thrace, 1903	Tens of thousands	Crushed	Crushed by the Ottoman army after ≈20 days	source
Kronstadt Soviet	Russia, 1921	≈18,000	Be-trayed	Stormed by the Red Army ; rebels executed or exiled	source
Cherán †	Michoacán, Mexico, 2011–present	≈16,000	Alive	Survives , legally recognised indigenous autonomy	source
Recovered factories †	Argentina, 2001–present	≈16,000 workers	Alive	Survives , pressured under the Milei government	source
Alcoy insurrection	Alcoy, Spain, 1873	≈10,000	Crushed	Retaken by the federal army within days	source
Exarcheia	Athens, 1970s–present	Thousands	Alive	Survives , under ongoing police eviction pressure	source

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
Magonista Baja California	Mexico, 1911	Thousands	Crushed	Defeated by federal troops; the PLM suppressed	source
Alt Llobregat rising	Catalonia, Spain, 1932	≈3,000	Crushed	Retaken by army and Civil Guard; militants deported	source
CHAZ / CHOP	Seattle, USA, 2020	A few thousand	Collapsed	Collapsed in ≈3 weeks; cleared by police	source
Marinaleda	Spain, 1979–present	≈2,700	Alive	Survives as a functioning cooperative	source
Christiania Freetown	Copenhagen, 1971–present	≈1,000	Alive	Survives, semi-legalised, under constant property pressure	source